

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Bookkeeping and Payroll English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Bookkeepers, accounts payable and receivable clerks, payroll clerks, and accounting assistants.

All organizations, records, amounts, deadlines, and incidents are fictional English-language practice. This course is not accounting, payroll-system, tax, employment-law, financial, or payment-processing advice. Internal deadlines in the exercises are not legal rules. Refer pay entitlements, deductions, posting treatments, corrections, and payment decisions to the responsible qualified people and applicable local requirements. Use invented employee and account details only.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Matching an invoice to its supporting records

Clarify which document supports a billed quantity.

02 Explaining receipts and outstanding customer balances

Explain why received cash and open invoice balances can coexist.

03 Qualifying a bank reconciliation difference

Report a traced item without overstating the reconciliation's completion.

04 Requesting evidence for time exceptions

Request confirmation of actual time without substituting a schedule for evidence.

05 Explaining a payroll preview

Explain a preview difference while separating arithmetic from approval.

06 Making approval status unambiguous

Give a payment status update that preserves each decision stage.

07 Handing over a period-close review

Hand over supporting facts and ownership without deciding accounting treatment.

08 Correcting records while preserving the trail

Repair an inaccurate status and preserve the distinction between an entry and a payment.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Matching an invoice to its supporting records

Clarify which document supports a billed quantity.

CASE

Fictional supplier Alder bills twelve desk lamps on invoice A184. Purchase order P61 lists twelve, but receiving record R9 lists ten. The remaining two may be on another delivery; no second record is available.

Teach this move

Name the invoice, order, and receiving record separately. Agreement between two documents does not settle a third document's different quantity. Ask about the missing evidence without assuming either a supplier error or an unrecorded delivery.

Vocabulary to check: invoice, purchase order, receiving record, credit note.

Model response

Invoice A184 and purchase order P61 both show twelve lamps, while receiving record R9 shows ten. Could you confirm whether the other two arrived separately or remain outstanding? I need the related delivery reference before I can describe the invoice as fully matched. At present, the two-lamp difference is unresolved.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question identifies the evidence gap without treating an unexplained difference as a confirmed error.

Second-round challenge

The supplier sends the purchase order again. Explain why it confirms the order quantity but not receipt.

Language-check answers

1. C - whether the other two lamps were received Correct. Receipt of the remaining two is the missing fact.
2. B - unresolved Correct. Unresolved preserves the open question.

05 • Conversations

1. Two lamps without a receiving reference - A fictional bookkeeper calls the buyer about invoice A184 and receiving record R9.

2. A credit note for the wrong invoice - A fictional supplier representative and clerk compare a credit note with two similar invoices.

3. Cases or individual folders - A fictional invoice query concerns a supplier's unit of measure.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A service invoice without a completion reference

Fictional invoice S12 bills two training sessions. The booking email confirms two sessions, but the completion record lists only one. The coordinator can check attendance records; the second session's status is unknown.

Role A: Bookkeeper: distinguish booked sessions from completed sessions and request the missing reference.

Role B: Training coordinator: one attendance list is available; the instructor holds the other session's records.

Possible opening: The booking covers two sessions, but I can currently support completion of only one.

Success checks

- Name the missing second-session evidence.
- Avoid calling the bill wrong before checking.
- Agree who will obtain the completion record.

Add a complication: The supplier resends the booking confirmation instead of completion evidence.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining receipts and outstanding customer balances

Explain why received cash and open invoice balances can coexist.

CASE

Fictional customer Pine has invoices 410 for \$600 and 411 for \$400. A \$600 receipt is identified as Pine's but has no invoice reference. Both invoices remain open in the ledger pending allocation.

Teach this move

A receipt records money received. Allocation connects it to a particular balance. Do not equate an unallocated receipt with nonpayment, or assume the customer's intended allocation from the amount alone.

Vocabulary to check: accounts receivable, remittance advice, unapplied cash, aging report.

Model response

We have received Pine's six hundred dollars, but the invoice allocation is still unconfirmed. The open invoices total one thousand dollars; the unapplied receipt must be shown alongside them. A remittance advice identifies what the customer intended to pay. Could you confirm the invoice reference so we can explain the remaining balance accurately?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The correction acknowledges cash already received instead of presenting the gross invoice balance as the entire position.

Second-round challenge

The amount equals invoice 410. Explain why that is a useful clue, not confirmation of the intended allocation.

Language-check answers

1. B - allocation Correct. Allocation links the recorded receipt to the intended invoice.
2. A - alongside Correct. Alongside means presenting the two relevant items together.

05 · Conversations

1. Pine's payment without an invoice number - A fictional customer and clerk resolve the intended allocation of a recorded \$600 receipt.
2. A receipt across two invoices - A fictional clerk checks a customer's breakdown of a combined payment.
3. Which date drives the aging column? - A fictional customer queries why an invoice appears in a report's overdue group.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The receipt belongs to a sister company

A fictional \$800 receipt names Cedar Group. Cedar North owes \$800 and Cedar South owes \$500. The remittance contact knows which entity paid but the bank reference omits it.

Role A: Receivables clerk: ask for the paying entity and invoice reference without allocating solely by amount.

Role B: Customer contact: the payment came from Cedar North for invoice N8; provide this only after the clerk asks.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which Cedar entity sent the eight hundred dollars and which invoice it covers?

Success checks

- Confirm the entity and invoice separately.
- Acknowledge the receipt without calling both accounts cleared.
- Restate the supplied N8 allocation.

Add a complication: A colleague says the matching amount makes the entity question unnecessary.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Qualifying a bank reconciliation difference

Report a traced item without overstating the reconciliation's completion.

CASE

In a fictional reconciliation through June 30, the bank balance is \$300 lower than the cash ledger. A \$300 deposit recorded June 30 appears on the bank's July 1 activity. Other reconciliation checks are not complete.

Teach this move

Separate the evidence for an individual item from the conclusion about the whole account. 'Consistent with' allows a supported explanation without claiming that every other entry has been checked.

Vocabulary to check: bank reconciliation, outstanding payment, deposit in transit, reconciling item.

Model response

The three-hundred-dollar deposit recorded on June thirty appears in the bank's July first activity. That supports a timing explanation for this item. It does not establish that the whole reconciliation is complete, because the other checks are still open. I would label this deposit as traced and keep the overall review pending.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision describes a supported timing difference instead of suggesting missing money.

Second-round challenge

A colleague says equal balances prove every entry is right. Distinguish agreeing totals from checking the underlying items.

Language-check answers

1. A - outstanding Correct. Outstanding means not yet completed in this context.
2. D - consistent with Correct. The later appearance supports the timing explanation.

05 • Conversations

1. A deposit appears one day later - A fictional reviewer discusses the June 30 reconciliation with the bookkeeper.

2. Equal totals with an unmatched pair - A fictional reconciliation review finds two equal and opposite unexplained amounts.

3. A bank fee or a look-alike amount - A fictional clerk checks an unexplained bank debit with a senior bookkeeper.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A cheque still absent from bank activity

A fictional \$420 cheque is recorded on August 28 but absent from bank activity through August 31. The recipient has not confirmed receipt. No loss or cancellation is established.

Role A: Bookkeeper: explain the outstanding payment and ask what evidence is needed.

Role B: Payments clerk: you have the issue record but no delivery or bank-clearing confirmation.

Possible opening: The cheque is recorded internally, but it has not appeared in the bank activity we reviewed.

Success checks

- Keep issued, received, and cleared distinct.
- Do not infer loss from absence at this cutoff.
- Assign follow-up on receipt and later bank activity.

Add a complication: Someone calls it lost because it is not yet cleared.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Requesting evidence for time exceptions

Request confirmation of actual time without substituting a schedule for evidence.

CASE

Fictional employee Eli's Tuesday timecard lacks a clock-out entry. The roster says 17:00, but Eli recalls 17:30. The supervisor can review a work log before the internal approval cutoff at 14:00 today. Actual finish time is unconfirmed.

Teach this move

Describe the absent entry and the conflicting information. An internal cutoff is a workflow deadline, not a statement about legal pay obligations. Ask the responsible reviewer for evidence and a status if the question cannot be resolved.

Vocabulary to check: time exception, missing punch, pay period, approval cutoff.

Model response

Could you review Eli's Tuesday finish time against the work log and confirm the supported correction before our internal two o'clock approval cutoff? The roster shows five, while Eli recalls five thirty. Neither should be presented as verified yet. If the evidence is still incomplete, please return the exception with that uncertainty clearly stated.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The request asks for the disputed fact rather than treating usual hours as actual hours.

Second-round challenge

The reviewer finds only the planned roster. Keep the actual finish time unresolved and identify the next evidence holder.

Language-check answers

1. D - what time Eli actually finished Correct. The request identifies the missing actual time.
2. C - by Correct. By sets the deadline and permits an earlier return.

05 • Conversations

1. Eli's missing Tuesday finish - A fictional payroll clerk requests evidence before the internal two o'clock cutoff.

2. An overnight shift crosses the date line - A fictional payroll clerk and shift supervisor clarify two timecard entries.

3. Two supervisors each expect the other to approve - A fictional payroll assistant resolves ownership of an internal time approval.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An exception arrives after the internal cutoff

A fictional time exception is received at 14:20 after a 14:00 internal cutoff. The employee disputes one hour. The payroll lead can review late-item handling at 15:00; no payment timing decision is supplied.

Role A: Payroll assistant: acknowledge receipt and escalate the specific exception without promising when money will arrive.

Role B: Supervisor: ask whether late receipt means the disputed hour will never be reviewed.

Possible opening: We received the one-hour query at two twenty; I have asked the payroll lead to review its handling at three.

Success checks

- State the actual receipt time and pending review.
- Do not turn an internal cutoff into a legal pay rule.
- Confirm who will communicate the handling decision.

Add a complication: The supervisor asks for a guaranteed correction in today's payment.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining a payroll preview

Explain a preview difference while separating arithmetic from approval.

CASE

Fictional preview A shows Morgan's gross pay of \$1,200, deductions of \$200, and net pay of \$1,000. Preview B shows the same gross pay, deductions of \$250, and net pay of \$950. A new \$50 deduction line is present; its supporting record is pending.

Teach this move

Keep the employee and pay period constant. Name gross pay, deductions, and net pay instead of using 'pay' for all three. A figure that adds up may still need supporting documentation.

Vocabulary to check: gross pay, deduction, net pay, payroll register.

Model response

Both previews show gross pay of twelve hundred dollars. Preview B has fifty dollars more in deductions, so the displayed net pay is fifty dollars lower. The new line explains the arithmetic difference, but its supporting record is still pending. Could you check that line before we describe preview B as ready for final approval?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision avoids describing a deduction change as a change in the underlying gross earnings.

Second-round challenge

Someone calls the extra fifty dollars a tax change. Explain that the line's reason is unconfirmed and requires the responsible specialist's review.

Language-check answers

1. C - whereas Correct. Whereas contrasts unchanged gross pay with changed deductions.
2. B - pending Correct. The record has not yet been confirmed.

05 • Conversations

1. Morgan's fifty-dollar preview difference - A fictional payroll reviewer and clerk compare previews A and B for the same employee and period.

2. A one-time amount disappears from the next preview - A fictional employee asks about differing gross figures across two payroll previews.
3. One more employee in the register - A fictional payroll assistant explains a headcount difference to a reviewer.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A year-to-date column mistaken for current pay

A fictional payslip preview lists current gross pay of \$900 and year-to-date gross pay of \$9,900. The employee thinks \$9,900 is the current payment. Deductions and final payment status are not supplied.

Role A: Payroll clerk: explain the two time spans without inventing a net amount.

Role B: Employee: ask which figure belongs to this period and whether it equals the bank payment.

Possible opening: The nine hundred is current gross pay; nine thousand nine hundred is the accumulated gross amount for the year.

Success checks

- Explain current versus accumulated totals.
- Distinguish gross pay from net pay.
- Leave the unsupplied payment amount unconfirmed.

Add a complication: The employee asks you to confirm the exact deposit based on gross pay alone.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Making approval status unambiguous

Give a payment status update that preserves each decision stage.

CASE

A fictional payment batch contains eight invoices. Seven have recorded approval; invoice V22 awaits a receiving document and is excluded from the proposed seven-item batch. The batch itself has not been released. The approver returns at 15:00.

Teach this move

Approval of an invoice, approval of a batch, and release of payment may be separate events. Use the fictional organization's stated stages, and avoid saying 'paid' merely because review is complete.

Vocabulary to check: payment batch, approval matrix, delegated approver, supporting document.

Model response

Seven invoices have recorded approval and are included in the proposed batch. V22 is excluded because its receiving document is still missing. The batch has not been released. The approver returns at three, when I can present the seven-item proposal and report separately on the missing document without calling the payments completed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised status does not turn completed review into completed payment.

Second-round challenge

A substitute colleague offers to approve the batch. Ask whether the recorded delegation covers this batch, without assuming seniority equals authority.

Language-check answers

1. B - but is awaiting Correct. Awaiting states that release is still pending.
2. A - receiving document Correct. The case identifies receipt evidence as the blocker.

05 · Conversations

1. Seven approved invoices are not seven completed payments - A fictional clerk updates a manager on the proposed batch and excluded V22.
2. A delegation that covers only smaller invoices - A fictional clerk checks a substitute reviewer's stated authority.
3. The attachment is not the approved version - A fictional invoice clerk checks conflicting attachment versions with an approver.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The approver confirms receipt of the email only

A fictional approver replies 'Received, thank you' to a four-invoice proposal. No decision is stated. The clerk can ask for explicit approval or a query before the 16:00 review meeting.

Role A: Accounts clerk: ask whether the reply acknowledges delivery or records a decision.

Role B: Approver: you only acknowledged the email and will review the proposal at 15:30.

Possible opening: Does your reply confirm receipt of the proposal, or have you completed the approval review?

Success checks

- Distinguish acknowledgment from approval.
- State the supplied review time without inventing a decision.
- Keep the proposal pending until a decision is given.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to mark all four invoices approved based on the acknowledgment.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handing over a period-close review

Hand over supporting facts and ownership without deciding accounting treatment.

CASE

Fictional June close has nine of ten checklist items complete. A \$240 maintenance invoice dated July 2 describes June service. Its posting period needs the accountant's review; no adjusting entry has been approved. Alex takes over the open-item follow-up at noon.

Teach this move

Invoice date, service period, and posting period can differ. Preserve them separately and name the person who will obtain the accountant's decision. A balanced trial balance does not answer every period question.

Vocabulary to check: close checklist, posting period, adjusting entry, trial balance.

Model response

Nine of the ten June close checks are complete. The open item is the two-hundred-forty-dollar maintenance invoice dated July second for June service. Its posting period needs the accountant's review, and no adjustment is approved. Alex, please confirm that you are taking over that follow-up and will keep the close status pending until the review outcome is recorded.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies the unfinished work and its owner without implying the close is complete.

Second-round challenge

The accountant is unavailable until tomorrow. State the owner and pending question without assigning an invented posting period.

Language-check answers

1. A - subject to Correct. Subject to means dependent on the review outcome.
2. D - am taking over Correct. Taking over accepts follow-up responsibility.

05 · Conversations

1. Alex takes the maintenance-period query - A fictional noon handover concerns the final June close item.
2. A balanced trial balance with a missing reference - A fictional assistant asks a reviewer whether equal totals settle an open close question.
3. A schedule total agrees after one item is added - A fictional bookkeeper hands a corrected supporting schedule to a reviewer.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A close folder with two unreviewed schedules

A fictional checklist marks cash and supplier schedules prepared, but both reviewer boxes are empty. The reviewer can take cash today; supplier review needs another named colleague.

Role A: Bookkeeper: distinguish prepared from reviewed and arrange the two ownership checks orally.

Role B: Reviewer: accept cash review only and ask who will take suppliers.

Possible opening: Both schedules are prepared, but neither has a recorded review yet.

Success checks

- Separate file preparation from review completion.
- Confirm the cash reviewer.
- Keep supplier review unassigned until someone accepts it.

Add a complication: A manager asks to report the entire folder as complete because all files are present.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Correcting records while preserving the trail

Repair an inaccurate status and preserve the distinction between an entry and a payment.

CASE

In fictional tracker version 3, invoice J14 for \$180 appears twice because the same file was imported twice. The controller confirmed one duplicate. No ledger correction has been posted. A previous message wrongly said the duplicate payment had been recovered; no duplicate payment is established.

Teach this move

State exactly what the earlier message got wrong. A duplicate document, entry, and payment are different findings. Refer to the original record and correction status without teaching a universal reversal method.

Vocabulary to check: audit trail, reversal, duplicate entry, version history.

Model response

My earlier message confused a duplicate entry with a duplicate payment. The controller has confirmed a repeated one-hundred-eighty-dollar invoice entry in tracker version three; we have not established that money was paid twice. No ledger correction has been posted. I am correcting the status now and linking the original entry for the controller's review of the required correction.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The corrected statement removes unsupported claims about both payment and recovery.

Second-round challenge

A colleague proposes calling the issue fully fixed after updating the tracker. Distinguish the tracker correction from the still-pending ledger review.

Language-check answers

1. D - entry Correct. The confirmed issue is a repeated invoice entry.
2. C - supersedes Correct. Supersedes identifies the newer version as the current one.

05 • Conversations

1. An entry was duplicated, not a payment confirmed - A fictional clerk corrects a message about J14 in tracker version three.
2. The correction email pointed to the old file - A fictional bookkeeper repairs a version-link mistake with a colleague.
3. A proposed reversal is still only a proposal - A fictional clerk clarifies the status of an accounting correction during a review call.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | The wrong employee reference in a correction query

A fictional payroll query names employee R14, but the attached supporting note concerns R41. No pay change has been made. The payroll lead can confirm the intended record before review resumes.

Role A: Payroll assistant: acknowledge the transposed reference and pause the ambiguous query, not the employee's pay.

Role B: Payroll lead: ask which evidence identifies the intended record; you can confirm R41 from the note.

Possible opening: The query reference and supporting note disagree; no pay change has been made.

Success checks

- Correct the record reference using the supplied evidence.
- Do not infer an incorrect payment from a query error.
- Restate R41 and the unchanged payment status.

Add a complication: A colleague calls the mismatch proof that the wrong person was paid.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All organizations, records, amounts, deadlines, and incidents are fictional English-language practice. This course is not accounting, payroll-system, tax, employment-law, financial, or payment-processing advice. Internal deadlines in the exercises are not legal rules. Refer pay entitlements, deductions, posting treatments, corrections, and payment decisions to the responsible qualified people and applicable local requirements. Use invented employee and account details only.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: Bookkeeping, Accounting, and Auditing Clerks

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/office-and-administrative-support/bookkeeping-accounting-and-auditing-clerks.htm>

U.S. Department of Labor: Fact Sheet 21, Recordkeeping Requirements

<https://www.dol.gov/agencies/whd/fact-sheets/21-flsa-recordkeeping>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Bookkeeping and Payroll English

Professional audience: Bookkeepers, accounts payable and receivable clerks, payroll clerks, and accounting assistants

Scope: All organizations, records, amounts, deadlines, and incidents are fictional English-language practice. This course is not accounting, payroll-system, tax, employment-law, financial, or payment-processing advice. Internal deadlines in the exercises are not legal rules. Refer pay entitlements, deductions, posting treatments, corrections, and payment decisions to the responsible qualified people and applicable local requirements. Use invented employee and account details only.

Lesson 01: Matching an invoice to its supporting records

Original fictional case: Fictional supplier Alder bills twelve desk lamps on invoice A184. Purchase order P61 lists twelve, but receiving record R9 lists ten. The remaining two may be on another delivery; no second record is available.

Language workshop: Locate the exact mismatch

Communication goal: Clarify which document supports a billed quantity.

Language guidance: Name the invoice, order, and receiving record separately. Agreement between two documents does not settle a third document's different quantity. Ask about the missing evidence without assuming either a supplier error or an unrecorded delivery.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The invoice shows ___, whereas the receiving record shows ___. / Could you confirm whether ___ arrived separately? / Which reference supports the remaining ___?

Vocabulary: invoice: A supplier's or seller's bill listing goods or services and the amount requested. /

purchase order: A buyer's purchasing document specifying the goods or services ordered. / receiving

record: A record of the goods or quantities actually received by an organization. / credit note: A seller's

document reducing an amount previously billed, with a reference to the relevant charge.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Buyer: you ordered twelve lamps and can see only R9. The warehouse can check whether a second delivery occurred.

Guided response task: Complete a workplace dialogue by selecting one of four supplied options. Compare the feedback and say the completed exchange aloud. Do not write an open-ended message.

Optional second-round challenge: The supplier sends the purchase order again. Explain why it confirms the order quantity but not receipt.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Invoice A184 and purchase order P61 both show twelve lamps, while receiving record R9 shows ten. Could you confirm whether the other two arrived separately or remain outstanding? I need the related delivery reference before I can describe the invoice as fully matched. At present, the two-lamp difference is unresolved.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt a supported occupational language lesson

1. Ask for learner support needs, group size and time. Offer two B2 learners and 20 minutes as a default and wait for confirmation.
2. Use the reference's real language goal, terms and case facts. Provide a timed plan containing reading, four-choice dialogue gaps, scaffolded speaking, focused feedback and a retry. No activity may require open-ended writing.
3. Give two separate speaking role cards with known facts, an objective, a possible opening, one question to resolve and three success checks. Put model responses in a separate teacher section. Label invented complications and preserve uncertainty.
4. Include four original gap-fill exchanges with four plausible options each and exactly one answer. Provide option-specific explanations separately. B1 support adds a word bank and frames; C1 stretch uses more nuanced choices and spoken follow-up, not essays. Include solo rehearsal of both roles.
5. Check facts, terminology, answer uniqueness and timing before presenting the plan. Finish with a four-choice exit question and an optional spoken retry. Do not certify proficiency or teach professional procedures.

END PROMPT

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Bookkeeping and Payroll English

Professional audience: Bookkeepers, accounts payable and receivable clerks, payroll clerks, and accounting assistants

Scope: All organizations, records, amounts, deadlines, and incidents are fictional English-language practice. This course is not accounting, payroll-system, tax, employment-law, financial, or payment-processing advice. Internal deadlines in the exercises are not legal rules. Refer pay entitlements, deductions, posting treatments, corrections, and payment decisions to the responsible qualified people and applicable local requirements. Use invented employee and account details only.

Lesson 01: Matching an invoice to its supporting records

Original fictional case: Fictional supplier Alder bills twelve desk lamps on invoice A184. Purchase order P61 lists twelve, but receiving record R9 lists ten. The remaining two may be on another delivery; no second record is available.

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END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the wording to the listener

1. Quote one actual utterance from the reference. Identify its purpose, audience and degree of certainty. Offer a colleague, supervisor or outside customer as the new listener. Wait for my selection.
2. Supply four possible versions A-D and a specific constraint, such as explaining an unfamiliar abbreviation without changing a pending decision into approval. Make exactly one version satisfy all constraints. Wait for my choice.
3. Explain the strengths and limitations of every option. Treat valid stylistic alternatives as alternatives, not mistakes; rewrite an ambiguous question instead of rejecting reasonable English. Avoid national stereotypes.
4. Continue with three short, role-labelled exchanges in which I select the missing reply from four choices. Include a clarification and a disagreement. Wait after each item and invite a spoken rehearsal after feedback.
5. Finish with two complete model exchanges for different listeners. Identify what changed and what stayed the same. Do not assign open-ended writing.

END PROMPT